

The 10k roadmap

Week 6, Lecture 1 · Grow on X: From Zero to 10,000 Followers

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Three growth phases and what defines each (0→1k, 1k→5k, 5k→10k)
- How content strategy, distribution, and network moves differ at each phase
- Milestone planning with realistic timelines: what the data says
- Common stalls at 500, 2k, and 8k: causes and remedies

Part 1: three phases

The same account, three different games

- Growth from 0 to 10k is not one continuous sprint. It is three separate games.
- Each game has different winning moves. What works at phase 1 fails at phase 3.
- Welsh (2023): "Success (in anything) is all about playing the long game."
- Most creators apply phase 1 tactics forever and wonder why they stall at 2k.

Phase 1: 0 to 1k (proving the niche)

- The only goal: find the specific topic and format that your target reader shares
- Borrowed distribution matters more than your own: replies, quote-posts, collaborations
- Post volume is low; post quality and positioning clarity are everything
- Milestone: your first post that earns 10 follows from people you do not already know

Phase 2: 1k to 5k (compounding distribution)

- You now have a small base. The goal is to make that base replicate itself.
- Original content starts to carry reach: your followers share because you are consistent
- Newsletter or email list becomes essential: you need off-platform backup (Barry, 2023)
- Collaboration upgrades: you have enough social proof for peer-level creators to say yes

Phase 3: 5k to 10k (network leverage)

- At 5k, your posts reach people you have never met through second-degree shares
- Network leverage: the right relationship with one 50k account accelerates months of solo work
- Defense begins: protect the content quality and posting system that got you here
- Monetization becomes real: 5k is the threshold where most sponsorship inquiries start

Part 2: what changes at each phase

Content strategy shifts

Phase 1 and 2

Phase 3

- Single-idea posts, threads
 - Teach one thing per post: clear promise, clear payoff
 - Short-form wins: fewer words to understand means wider sharing
 - Format experiments: test 4-6 formats, kill the weak ones fast
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- Long-form begins to pay: your audience trusts you enough to read 1,500 words
 - Pattern recognition: you know which formats your audience shares most

Distribution strategy shifts

- Phase 1: reply to every post in your niche with a substantive take. Be findable.
- Phase 2: collaborate. Guest threads, swap reposts with creators at your tier.
- Phase 3: a single viral post can add 500-1,000 follows in 48 hours. Build the machine that produces those posts, then wait.
- Barry (2023): the creator flywheel spins faster with each rotation once the base is established.

Network strategy shifts

- Phase 1: follow 30-50 accounts at your same size. Comment before they know you.
- Phase 2: reach up one tier. A creator at 10k who reposts you is worth 200 solo posts.
- Phase 3: the network is now incoming. Protect it by being useful to people who mention you.
- Welsh (2023): at 750k followers, 90% of the work is still making each individual reader feel seen.

Part 3: milestone planning

Realistic growth rates by phase

- Phase 1 (0→1k): median 4-6 months for a focused creator posting 5x/week
- Phase 2 (1k→5k): median 6-12 months. Compounding starts to appear in months 4-6 of this phase.
- Phase 3 (5k→10k): median 3-6 months once the flywheel is running. Phase 3 is often faster than phase 2.
- Total: 13-24 months for a creator starting from zero, posting consistently, iterating on feedback

Building your milestone plan

1. Set a 30-day target for each of the next three months (not a single 90-day number)
2. Make the phase 1 target honest: 100-250 follows in 30 days is realistic
3. Make the phase 2 target reflect compounding: the rate should increase each month
4. Include a trigger: if you miss the 30-day target by more than 25%, the plan tells you what to check first

Part 4: stall points

The stall at 500

- Cause: niche is right, but bio or pinned post is not converting profile visits
- Diagnostic: check profile-click-to-follow rate. If it is below 15%, the problem is on the profile page.
- Remedy: rewrite the bio, replace the pinned post with your three best pieces, check the header image
- The 500 stall is almost always a profile problem, not a content problem

The stall at 2k

- Cause: content that proved the niche is no longer surprising to the audience that followed you for it
- Diagnostic: compare engagement rate on posts from month 1 vs. month 6. If it has dropped significantly, the audience has heard your core argument.
- Remedy: introduce one adjacent topic, invite one collaborator from outside your niche, or go deeper on a sub-topic you have only skimmed

The stall at 8k

- Cause: the creator is operating in “maintenance mode.” Posting the same format, same cadence, same framing. The algorithm treats consistent-but-flat as a signal to reduce distribution.
- Diagnostic: when did you last post something that surprised your own followers?
- Remedy: one deliberate format change per month. Barry (2023): “Each rotation is easier than the previous rotation and produces more results” only if the wheel is still turning forward.

Each rotation is easier than the previous rotation and produces more results.

<footer>Nathan Barry, "Creator Flywheels," 2023</footer>

Take-aways

1. Growth from 0 to 10k is three distinct games. The tactics that win phase 1 actively hurt you in phase 3.
2. Borrowed distribution (replies, collaborations) dominates phase 1. Original distribution dominates phase 3. The transition happens somewhere in phase 2.
3. Stall points at 500, 2k, and 8k each have a specific diagnosis. Fix the right variable, not the loudest one.
4. Realistic timelines: 13-24 months from zero for a focused creator. Phase 3 is often the fastest phase.
5. A 30-day milestone plan with a trigger condition beats a 90-day aspiration with no check-in logic.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 6 reading builds your complete 90-day playbook from scratch
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Sustainable growth, burnout prevention, and monetization at 10k
- **Section (this week):** Capstone demo day. Arrive with your full playbook document.
- **HW 4 (due this week):** 30-day experiment conclusions feed directly into your milestone plan